



UNIVERSITY INTERSCHOLASTIC LEAGUE

Making a World of Difference

CURRENT ISSUES & EVENTS

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2022 • REGION

March 21, 2022



Photo by Bradley Wilson

Texas Gov. Greg Abbott poses with a group of supporters at a campaign stop in Wichita Falls, Texas. Abbott appeared along with Arkansas gubernatorial candidate Sarah Huckabee Sanders, former White House press secretary, and elected state officials.

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CURRENT ISSUES & EVENTS

REGION • 2022

- 1. On March 16, U.S. President Joe Biden detailed \$350 million in additional aid to Ukraine. What did he NOT include?**
 - a. anti-air systems
 - b. armed patrol boats
 - c. transport helicopters
 - d. Soviet-built MiG-29 combat jets
- 2. Microsoft shut down what professional networking service in China, citing “a significantly more challenging operating environment and greater compliance requirements”?**
 - a. Teams
 - b. Skype
 - c. LinkedIn
 - d. Reddit
- 3. The Federal Reserve announced it would raise interest rates for the first time in three years to cool red-hot inflation, a move that comes at a precarious time for the U.S. economy as it confronts a continuing pandemic and a war in Europe. The benchmark federal funds, when raised, would be in what range?**
 - a. between 0% and 0.25%
 - b. between 0.25% and 0.5%
 - c. between 1% and 2%
 - d. between 2.3% and 4.3%
- 4. President Biden issued a proclamation to observe Oct. 11 as a day to honor Native Americans, their resilience and their contributions to American society throughout history, even as they faced assimilation, discrimination and genocide spanning generations. The day was originally designated as Columbus Day to honor what?**
 - a. the day Christopher Columbus landed in the Bahamas
 - b. the day Native American slaves were set free
 - c. the day Spain defeated America, roughly corresponding to Oct. 12, 1492
 - d. the day Spanish colonies in the Caribbean declared their independence from Spain
- 5. After losing an hour of sleep over the weekend, members of the U.S. Senate returned to the Capitol a bit groggy. So, with almost no warning and no debate, the Senate unanimously passed legislation to do away with what?**
 - a. tax day
 - b. daylight saving time, making standard time permanent
 - c. standard time, making daylight saving time permanent
 - d. any exemptions to daylight saving time such as those in Indiana and Arizona
- 6. What country won the most medals (37) at the 2022 Winter Olympics and leads the all-time Olympic Games medal table for the Winter Olympic Games?**
 - a. United States
 - b. Norway
 - c. Germany
 - d. Soviet Union

7. **The chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, Gen. Mark Milley, in October said that, in what was very close to a “Sputnik moment,” China had tested what?**
 - a. an intercontinental ballistic missile that can carry bioterrorism weapons anywhere on the planet
 - b. a missile capable of carrying a crew of a dozen to Mars as part of an effort to be the first country to establish a colony there
 - c. a hypersonic missile designed to evade American nuclear defenses
 - d. a mining system designed to mine the moon
8. **BIG:LEAP is a new program in Los Angeles for what?**
 - a. unemployment income for the first 12 months after college graduation
 - b. free medical care for people older than 65
 - c. a bonus for married couples having children (\$3,000/child)
 - d. guaranteed basic income (\$1,000/month for a year)
9. **American intelligence officials have discovered that the barrage of ballistic missiles Russia has fired into Ukraine contain a surprise. What?**
 - a. decoys that trick air-defense radars and fool heat-seeking missiles
 - b. message encouraging citizens of Ukraine to surrender
 - c. a short-range, short-duration electromagnetic pulse rendering other technology useless
 - d. chlorine
10. **On Nov. 24 at 1:21 a.m. Eastern time, NASA launched a 1,200-pound, refrigerator-size spacecraft. It will trek around the sun to slam into a small asteroid named Dimorphos at 15,000 miles per hour next year with what goal?**
 - a. to determine if we can land a spacecraft on an asteroid
 - b. to determine if we can deflect an asteroid headed toward Earth
 - c. to determine if we can mine minerals from asteroids
 - d. to determine if water on earth might have come from asteroids
11. **The National Suicide Prevention Lifeline — the number posted on student identification cards, atop Google search results and in warning labels on television shows — is about to get a major reboot, casting it as the 911 for mental health. The upgraded Lifeline starting in July will have what number?**
 - a. 891
 - b. 119
 - c. 988
 - d. 311
12. **Attorney General Merrick Garland said the Justice Department filed a lawsuit against the state of Texas, claiming what had been done to deny equal opportunity to Black and Latino voters, despite most of the state’s population growth being among people of color?**
 - a. Mask mandates were removed at in-person voting locations.
 - b. The Texas Legislature drew new congressional districting maps.
 - c. The Texas Legislature wrote new housing rules that effectively allowed discrimination.
 - d. The Texas Legislature said all voting would be on election day.

- 13. President Joe Biden selected D.C. Circuit Court of Appeals Judge Ketanji Brown Jackson as his nominee to succeed retiring Justice Stephen Breyer. She's the first Black woman nominated to the nation's highest court. She's also the first what?**
 - a. first woman to be nominated
 - b. first former prosecutor appointed to the federal judiciary
 - c. first former public defender to join the court
 - d. first Supreme Court nominee to have graduated from an Ivy League school

- 14. According to a high court in the United Kingdom, Julian Assange can be extradited to the U.S. to face espionage charges, although his supporters call this ruling a blow to press freedom. Assange was founder of what?**
 - a. WikiLeaks
 - b. Facebook
 - c. Wikipedia
 - d. the dark web

- 15. The military government convicted former leader Aung San Suu Kyi on charges of incitement and breaking COVID rules and sentenced her to two years in prison. The 1991 Nobel Peace Prize laureate was president of what country?**
 - a. Thailand
 - b. Vietnam
 - c. Nepal
 - d. Myanmar (Burma)

- 16. Shares of this technology company were trading at an all-time high of \$182.88 in early January. The company passed \$2 trillion in 2020 and \$1 trillion in 2018. Now, it is the first publicly traded company to ever be worth \$3 trillion. What company?**
 - a. Microsoft
 - b. Alphabet (Google)
 - c. Amazon
 - d. Apple

- 17. Months of testimony in a San Jose courtroom centered on allegations that Elizabeth Holmes perpetrated a massive fraud at the startup she founded after dropping out of Stanford at age 19. Prosecutors alleged that she misrepresented technology to patients, doctors and investors, and prematurely deployed tests in the field. What kind of technology/tests?**
 - a. mobile skin testing for melanoma cancer
 - b. MRI scans from a hand-held device
 - c. a lie detector that works by scanning a person's eyes
 - d. blood testing

- 18. Consuming less of what product will play a key role in helping Spain mitigate the effects of the climate emergency, slow the process of desertification, and protect its vital tourism industry, the country's consumer affairs minister has said?**
 - a. olives
 - b. meat
 - c. wine
 - d. tangerines

19. “Flurona” refers to what?

- a. a new strand of coronavirus (technically, the pi variant)
- b. a new, highly infectious respiratory virus transmitted by insects
- c. a new disease that got started in Israel in January affecting unvaccinated women and children
- d. a dual infection of the flu virus and coronavirus

20. Why did Verizon and AT&T delay the rollout of 5G?

- a. The airline industry expressed concern that it could interfere with systems on planes.
- b. It reached only 0.1% of the U.S. population and wasn’t yet effective.
- c. It put a strain on the electrical grid in Texas during cold winter months.
- d. T-Mobile, the top cellphone provider, sued, claiming patent infringement.



21. The U.S. Mint began shipping quarters that commemorate pioneering American women. Who is depicted on the first one?

- a. Maya Angelou
- b. Harriet Tubman
- c. bell hooks
- d. Kamala Harris

22. The Census Bureau said that the overall population total was accurate but that what group was overcounted?

- a. Native Americans
- b. Asian Americans
- c. Blacks
- d. Hispanics

23. What country plans to name its new capital Nusantara, which translates as “archipelago,” when government offices are relocated to the province of East Kalimantan from Jakarta, on the island of Java?

- a. Indonesia
- b. Tonga
- c. Papa New Guinea
- d. Madagascar

24. David Ortiz made history this year doing something Roger Clemens and Barry Bonds couldn’t do. What?

- a. He broke the major league home run record with 762 home runs during his career.
- b. He struck out 4,672 players, a career record.
- c. He had a .279 batting average, a season record.
- d. He got named to the Baseball Hall of Fame.

- 25. In 2017, the A68A iceberg snapped off the Antarctic Peninsula and subsequently traveled almost 2,500 miles over 3.5 years. It was the biggest iceberg on Earth when it formed and the sixth largest on record. But in 2022, scientists said what lasting effects of the iceberg could be felt for years to come?**
- It lowered ocean temperatures by at least 2°C worldwide.
 - It carried with it a considerable number of penguins and seals who made it as far north as South Georgia Island, a British overseas territory, which they now inhabit.
 - It contributed 1 trillion tons of water into the ocean, fresh water that could change the salty sea around it.
 - It dumped tons of bacteria and plankton from prehistoric days into the water, life forms that had never before seen in today's oceans.
- 26. To play the game, players guess a predetermined five-letter word in just six tries. In the span of three months, what game went from a personal gift to a viral sensation?**
- Wordle
 - Minecraft
 - Animal Crossing: New Horizons
 - Candy Crush
- 27. While the company said it also donated \$25,000 to Texas Democrats, which company came under fire after a report claimed it donated \$15,000 to Republican lawmakers who support the Texas abortion ban?**
- Dr Pepper
 - Pepsi
 - Coca-Cola
 - Cheerwine
- 28. According to a *New York Times* report, six weeks after Election Day, with his hold on power slipping, President Donald J. Trump directed his lawyer, Rudolph W. Giuliani, to make a remarkable call. Trump wanted him to ask the Department of Homeland Security if it could legally take control of what?**
- local police officials
 - news agencies
 - voting machines
 - the electoral college
- 29. Sony Interactive Entertainment has agreed to acquire privately held video game developer Bungie for \$3.6 billion, adding to a flurry of industry consolidation. Bungie is the company behind which multiplayer shooter game?**
- Halo
 - Far Cry
 - Amid Evil
 - Team Fortress
- 30. ISIS leader Abu Ibrahim al-Hashimi al-Qurayshi was killed during a U.S. counterterrorism raid. It was the biggest raid in what country since the 2019 operation that killed ISIS leader Abu Bakr al-Baghdadi?**
- Iran
 - Syria
 - Turkey
 - Saudi Arabia

31. **Former Alaska Gov. Sarah Palin tested positive for COVID-19, forcing the delay of her trial. She sued *The New York Times* for what?**
 - a. copyright violation
 - b. invasion of privacy
 - c. defamation
 - d. releasing classified documents
32. **Mayor Jacob Frey suspended no-knock warrants after police shot and killed Amir Locke, a 22-year-old Black man. Where?**
 - a. Cornelia, Georgia
 - b. Louisville, Kentucky
 - c. Potomac, Maryland
 - d. Minneapolis, Minnesota
33. **According to early research published in bioRxiv, what animals in New York City and in 15 states were found to be infected with the omicron variant of COVID-19, worrying health experts that the species could become a reservoir for the virus?**
 - a. roaches
 - b. deer
 - c. raccoons
 - d. bats
34. **Drought, bush fires, disease and habitat loss have drastically reduced the numbers of what animal declared an endangered species in February?**
 - a. koala
 - b. Amur tiger
 - c. numbat
 - d. regent honeyeater
35. **Fueled by politically vulnerable lawmakers who recognize the potency of signaling to voters that they will act on the perceived corruption in Washington, a bipartisan push was growing early this year to do what — especially after it received support from Nancy Pelosi if it also applied to members of the judicial branch?**
 - a. ban elected or senior appointed officials from running for one office while holding another
 - b. ban anyone in the federal government from serving a life term in office
 - c. ban ownership and trading of individual stocks
 - d. ban elected or senior appointed officials from getting raises in their wages until after the next election
36. **A woman of mixed race appeared to be the third person ever cured of HIV, according to announcements in January. What method was used?**
 - a. transplant involving umbilical cord blood
 - b. antiretroviral drugs
 - c. transplant of stem cells from a pig
 - d. radiation used to fight her leukemia
37. **Under the terms of an agreement, the athletes will receive \$24 million and a pledge from their federation to equalize pay for the men's and women's national teams in what sport?**
 - a. ice skating
 - b. fastpitch
 - c. hockey
 - d. soccer

- 38. Days before the invasion of Ukraine, Russian President Vladimir Putin and Russian officials recognized the independence of two separatist-claimed regions of eastern Ukraine. Which two?**
- a. Chernobyl and Odessa
 - b. Donetsk and Luhansk
 - c. Kyiv and Lviv
 - d. Moldova and Crimea
- 39. Texas threw out mail votes at an abnormally high rate during the nation’s first primary of 2022, rejecting nearly 23,000 ballots outright, according to an analysis by the Associated Press. Why?**
- a. more deceased people allegedly voted
 - b. voter fraud was rampant with thousands of people voting more than once
 - c. tougher election laws
 - d. Republicans controlled the voting booths and indiscriminately discarded ballots from Democrats
- 40. More than 40 homes were destroyed. Cars were mangled. An Eastland County Deputy Barbara Fenley died helping people evacuate. It became the largest event of its kind in Texas. What?**
- a. an EF-5 tornado
 - b. a flash flood
 - c. an earthquake
 - d. a wildfire

THE ESSAY

NOTE: *Contestants who do not write an essay will be disqualified.* Essay length is not a major grading factor as long as the essay is substantial and demonstrates a sincere effort to discuss the assigned topic. Cover as many corners of the issue as practical, including historical, political, economic, social and cultural, when relevant. Avoid including your personal opinions, as more than enough information on the subject has been published.

A focused, concise and specific essay beats a vague and rambling essay.

PROMPT

As Reid Epstein said in his March 2, 2022 article in *The New York Times*, “For nearly a decade, the refrain from Texas Democrats has been that they are on the verge of making their state competitive, even though no Democrat has won a statewide race since 1994. [As the first primary contest of 2022, the Texas] primary results illustrated that Democrats still have a long way to go.”

What does he mean? Using specific examples related to this election in Texas, the first since the Census, discuss the outcome of the primary and the factors that influenced the outcome of the primary.

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ANSWER KEY

ESSAY PROMPT

As Reid Epstein said in his March 2, 2022 article in *The New York Times*, “For nearly a decade, the refrain from Texas Democrats has been that they are on the verge of making their state competitive, even though no Democrat has won a statewide race since 1994. [As the first primary contest of 2022, the Texas] primary results illustrated that Democrats still have a long way to go.”

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POTENTIAL DISCUSSION POINTS PREPARED March 20, 2022 might include, but should not be limited to...

- | | |
|-------|-------|
| 1. D | 21. A |
| 2. C | 22. B |
| 3. B | 23. A |
| 4. A | 24. D |
| 5. C | 25. C |
| 6. B | 26. A |
| 7. C | 27. B |
| 8. D | 28. C |
| 9. A | 29. A |
| 10. B | 30. B |
| 11. C | 31. C |
| 12. B | 32. D |
| 13. C | 33. B |
| 14. A | 34. A |
| 15. D | 35. C |
| 16. D | 36. A |
| 17. D | 37. D |
| 18. B | 38. B |
| 19. D | 39. C |
| 20. A | 40. D |

- *Governor* — Greg Abbott won the GOP nomination for governor and will avoid a runoff. He will face popular Democrat Beto O'Rourke in November.
- *Attorney general* — Ken Paxton will face George P. Bush in a May runoff for the GOP nomination for attorney general.
- *Other top Texas officials* — Lt. Gov. Dan Patrick and Comptroller Glenn Hegar also cruised to their party's nominations in their reelection bids, and Agriculture Commissioner Sid Miller won his primary race
- *Voter suppression* — In the run-up to primary day, much of the media coverage has focused on the disruptions to early voting caused by Senate Bill 1, the election reform law passed by the GOP-dominated Legislature last year. According to voter data obtained by *The New York Times*, election officials in the state's most populous counties had rejected 10% of absentee ballot applications as of Feb. 18, a major increase from past years. In Harris County, the largest, that number was 30%. The main culprit is a new requirement that voters use the same form of ID to request a paper ballot that they originally used to register—a major hassle for people who registered to vote decades ago.
- *Voter suppression* — The Texas Tribune's Alexa Ura and Mandi Cai reported that 18,742 ballots were tossed in 16 of the 20 Texas counties with the most voters. And the Associated Press reported, after a survey of 187 of the state's 254 counties, that 22,898 mail ballots — 13% of the total — were rejected this year. The normal rate of rejection is 2%. In the 2020 presidential election, the rejection rate was under 1%.
- *More on Senate Bill 1* — More than 440 bills with provisions that restrict voting access have been introduced in 49 states in the 2021 legislative sessions. SB1 passed the Texas Legislature. While SB 1 makes some changes that could expand access — namely increasing early voting hours in smaller, mostly Republican counties — the new law otherwise restricts how and when voters cast ballots. It specifically targets voting initiatives used by diverse, Democratic Harris County, the state's most populous, by banning overnight early voting hours and drive-thru voting — both of which proved popular among voters of color last year. The new law also will ratchet up voting-by-mail rules in a state where the option is already significantly limited, give partisan poll watchers increased autonomy inside polling places by granting them free movement, and set new rules — and criminal penalties — for voter assistance. It also makes it a state jail felony for local election officials to proactively distribute applications for mail-in ballots, even if they are providing them to voters who automatically qualify to vote by mail or groups helping get out the vote.
- *Voter turnout* — Most Texas voters skip the primary elections, leaving many of the decisions about who serves in office to a relatively small group of Texas. Around 17% of registered voters in Texas cast a ballot in the 2022 primary, according to preliminary turnout data from the secretary of state.
- *Census* — Texas gained the most residents of any state since 2010, and its Hispanic population is now nearly as large as the non-Hispanic white population, with just half a percentage point separating them. Texas gained nearly 11 Hispanic residents for every additional white resident since 2010. However, new election maps drawn by the Texas Legislature do not reflect those changes. The maps were drawn to keep Texas Republicans in power for the next decade. Texas' new election map does in fact strengthen Republican positioning overall in Texas, going from 22 to 25 districts that would have voted for Donald Trump in 2020. The number of congressional districts that voted for Joe Biden would have shrunk by one, from 14 to 13.

CONTESTANT NUMBER _____

CURRENT ISSUES & EVENTS

CONTESTANT ANSWER SHEET

DO NOT write your name or school on this paper. Clearly write the **LETTER** corresponding to the best response to each question in the space below. Each objective question is worth 1 point. Write your response to the essay on the paper provided. The essay is worth as much as 10 points. You have 60 minutes.

- | | |
|-----------|-----------|
| 1. _____ | 21. _____ |
| 2. _____ | 22. _____ |
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| 17. _____ | 37. _____ |
| 18. _____ | 38. _____ |
| 19. _____ | 39. _____ |
| 20. _____ | 40. _____ |



FOR JUDGE'S USE

Points from **OBJECTIVE**
questions (each correct
answer counts 1 point) _____

If in the top eight places,
add the points from the
ESSAY question _____

TOTAL POINTS _____

Reminder: Team score is based
on the cumulative score of the
multiple choice portion of the
contest only. Do not count the
essay scores toward the team
championship.